



Crown of the Andes

△ **Atahualpa Emerald**, the crown's centrepiece

The Crown of the Andes is a spectacular religious object, featuring the oldest collection of emeralds on a single artefact in the world. It was fashioned by Spanish craftsmen in the 16th century in Popayán (in present-day Colombia). When the conquistadors came to plunder Inca gold, they brought with them European diseases, and in 1590 a virulent strain of smallpox swept through the region. The faithful of Popayán prayed to the Virgin for deliverance and, miraculously, they were spared. In gratitude, they decided to create a fabulous crown for the statue of the Virgin in their cathedral.



Atahualpa, the last Inca emperor and guardian of the Atahualpa Emerald

The oldest parts of the crown are the orb and cross at the top. The rest was added, year by year, with donations from the congregation. The centrepiece is the Atahualpa Emerald, named after the last of the Inca emperors and reputedly seized after his defeat by the Spanish conquistador

Francisco Pizarro. The crown was displayed once a year during the majestic processions in Holy Week, but word of its splendour soon spread, and so, to protect it from treasure hunters, the church set up a clandestine group of local nobles called the Confraternity of the Immaculate Conception. At the first sign of trouble, its members were entrusted with dismantling the crown and hiding the sections in the jungle.

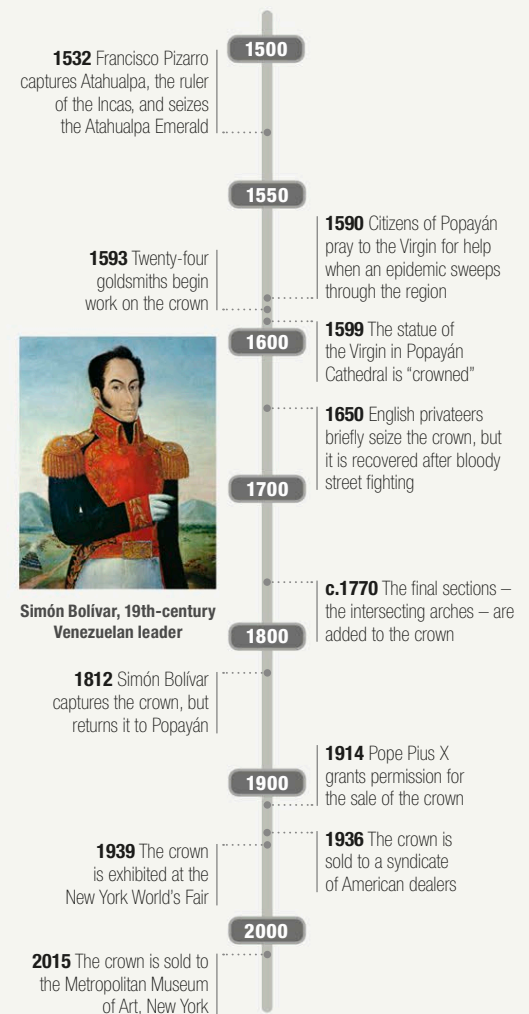
The group kept the crown safe until 1936, when the local clergy sold it to pay for a new hospital and orphanage. The buyers were a syndicate of American gem dealers, who wanted to break up the crown and sell its jewels. However, it proved such a popular attraction, including at the 1939 World's Fair, that this decision was reversed. It is now displayed intact at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, USA.



Virgin Mary, shown here in a Peruvian painting, c.1680, was an important figure in post-conquest, early Christian religious life in the Andes

Key dates

1532–2015



[The crown is] extraordinary for its rarity and its richness

Ronda **Kasl**
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